

KF 28 Expanded Version of Teachings

Karis is an invitation to a relationship based on mutual generosity.

“Search me, O God, and know my heart. Examine me and know my thoughts. See if there is any way in me that causes pain, and lead me in the ways of eternity.” (Psalm 139:23–24)

0:01 OPENING

0:02 PRESENTING

0:06 KARIS CIRCULATION

0:07 GUIDELINES & LIMITATIONS

0:08 MINDFULNESS & MEDITATION TRAINING

This month we will begin to practice a technique that I call **Calming Breath**. You might like to use this method when you are lying down, perhaps before going to sleep. As you breathe, you will explore the tension in your mind and body and then make a sound to signal your body to relax. So, please make sure that you are on mute while we practice together.

Calming Breath

1. Prepare

Assume a meditation posture, or you might wish to lie down. *(Pause)* Settle into the experience, or the experiment. You might begin with a silent prayer for peace within yourself and in your life. *(Pause for 30 seconds)*

2. Scan for tension

As you breathe, use your mind to scan the different parts of your body and observe any tension that you find. You might start with scanning your feet or ankles for one or two breaths, and then move to other areas of your body, including your face and jaw. As you exhale, try to let go of tension. Let the muscles in each area of your body drop or relax. *(Pause)* If you cannot relax an area, just observe it for now. This may be something that needs the help of a healing professional. Relax and breathe. *(Pause for 30 seconds)*

3. Use sound to release the tension

We will now practice using the word *CALM* as a centering word. Say the word *CALM* as you exhale and release tension in your body. Prolong the “ahm” sound as if you are releasing a sigh. I will give you an example. *(Offer two exhales as examples)* Continue at your own pace for one minute. *(Pause for 1 minute)*

When you feel ready, let go of saying the word. Whisper it or allow it to flow in your mind with the breath. Continue scanning and releasing body tension. *(Pause for 1 minute)*

And now, if you wish, allow the word to float away and use a long exhaling breath to release any tension in your body and mind. *(Pause for 1 minute)*

4. Rest

Now, take one minute to rest with a still, quiet mind. If you find your mind wandering, observe the breath, scan your body, or use the word *CALM* to draw your mind back to stillness. Breathe and rest. *(Pause for 1 minute)*

Pause. Gently stretch, open your eyes, and re-engage with the meeting. **Calming Breath** trains our bodies to calm down on command. It is out of the calm that we find our path to orientation. Take time throughout the day to calm yourself and give God a chance to guide you.

Our hymn for this meditation is *It Is Well with My Soul* by Horatio Spafford. You might read how this hymn was birthed out of intense personal grief. The Spaffords went on to create “The American Colony” in Jerusalem.

When peace like a river attendeth my way,
When sorrows like sea billows roll;
Whatever my lot, Thou hast taught me to say,
“It is well, it is well, with my soul.”¹

Take a deep breath.

(If time permits, ask, “Does anyone have comments or questions about this training?”)

0:20 KARIS CONFESSION

0:21 TOOLBOX

In this lesson we will begin exploring KF Confession 7:

We commit now to live in reality, choosing to believe rather than judge.

I wonder if sometime this week you will talk with God about your commitment to live in reality. You might not yet be ready to live in reality, but you can tell Him that, too. Just ask Him to help you.

At the beginning of our study of James, we talked about enduring—and even welcoming—life’s experiments as opportunities to examine our trust, or faith. We constantly need these experiments because through them we get to discover whether we are trusting God or our Idol Self. Comfortable living tends to deaden our awareness of what is really happening within us and around us. When we are comfortable and unchallenged, we complacently slip into the arrogant illusion that we can manage life on our own and no longer need to maintain our self-awareness. The whole world is looking for that place of numb, easy comfort.

Comfort is meant to be a temporary place of rest that is healing and restorative, but if you stay there, you will not discover your true glory. Continual comfort atrophies our ability to recognize and productively struggle with misorientation. In a state of continual comfort, we are like womb-children, supported without any effort on our part, living in darkness away from the light, lazy and warm, stunted, without responsibility, completely lacking in strength and skills. Warm, comfortable, and effortless living may

sound delightful at first, but it becomes a walking death. No growing creature is designed to remain in the womb-child condition.

Our culture teaches that living as womb-children is ideal. It tells us that it's only okay to be uncomfortable if you are doing something ambitious or thrilling—and personal growth is not considered ambitious or thrilling but, rather, something to be avoided. We are taught to judge discomfort, suffering, or adverse events as bad. Society, institutions and, especially, the media drill into our minds that we deserve and are entitled to comfort, and we readily accept what the media says because it supports our neurotic claims. If we have satisfactory jobs, average relationships and communities, and adequate health and wealth, we are happy enough. We unconsciously assert that comfort is what civilization is all about, so we judge any discomfort as an offense against our rights. Through our KF training, we now know how crazy this is, but we also recognize that the market economy and our institutions are not stupid. They teach us that comfort is our right, and they are ready to offer us the comfort we covet if we are willing spend our resources. If the people driving the market economy and institutions are uncomfortable, they feel it is their right to conscript our resources to regain their comfort. When we are not comfortable or do not get the support we imagine we deserve, we feel neglected or depressed and are compelled to spend and push. We relieve our discomfort by engaging in a kind of false circulation, spending resources and energy in ways that feed our illusions about who we are and what we deserve.

When we see that others are uncomfortable, we feel compelled to rescue them because we have been taught that if anyone is uncomfortable, it is somehow our business. Their discomfort imposes on us in some way, and we often feel irritated, guilty, scared, or just plain uncomfortable. We then divert our resources, which have been given to us for the development of our True Self, toward fixing, raging, blaming, worrying, rescuing, or sacrificing for others. But this only results in a temporary relief of our discomfort.

The sad thing is that the level of misery in a society tends to rise to match the level of resources allotted for relieving it. So, I'm encouraging you to use your resources wisely when dealing with suffering. Rather than working against misery, work for your true glory. There will always be suffering in the world and in our lives. When we live in reality, we embrace that fact—in other words, we believe it. Suffering and discomfort are part of the birthing process and will continue throughout our entire experience as material creatures. However, we can run away from our birthing process. For example, we can ignore conscious tension, or we can distract and medicate ourselves with addictive behaviors and chemicals. We can either lay low and hope that suffering will pass us by, or we can fight with the power of our will to overcome or deny suffering. However, none of these strategies for eliminating suffering and securing comfort will train or equip us to handle the inevitable suffering that is the reality of any creature living in a material, misoriented world. Our work in Christ as sons of God is to choose this birthing process, to go out and grapple with breathing and the surprising light of life. I often remind myself of this: *If I refuse to suffer, I refuse training. And if I refuse training, I am not skilled. And if I have no skills, I lack self-confidence. If I lack self-confidence, I make choices out of fear. If I am afraid, I will live my life motivated by chronic anxiety. Anxiety makes me short-tempered, greedy, egocentric, chaotic, and negligent. Anxiety drives me into misorientation and limits all of my options.*

Our goal in Karis Fellowships is not to avoid suffering but, rather, to learn how to manage the ravages of our self-hate and suffer productively. When we mindfully explore who we are, especially in our suffering, we discover our real strengths and weaknesses. We can then go into training to develop our soul muscles so that when experiments of life happen, we actually suffer less. We can learn to not be afraid.

Believe it or not, most of the suffering we encounter as Americans is self-imposed or imaginary. Often our suffering falls into the category of illusions. We suffer because of an imagined future, or because of an unprocessed past. We suffer because we are interpreting life according to our compelling needs or our shoulds and claims. We suffer because we are envying and blaming others in order to avoid taking responsibility for our own lives and well-being. We suffer because we imagine limitations that we do not actually have. We suffer because we have real limitations that do not support the *Glory of Me!*

Last week, we used the Tapas Acupressure Technique, or **T-A-T**, to work on imagined limitations and imagined perfection.² Try using the two-minute series of the **T-A-T** on your own this week to process an area of suffering that drives you into compulsive, distracting, or addictive behavior. You might find that your suffering exists only in your mind. Next week we will explore the **Suffering Worksheet**, which I designed to help you defuse, or to at least understand, some of your suffering.

We have taught ourselves to react compulsively and addictively through repeated action, learning, and memory. In just the same way, we can teach ourselves to respond joyfully to life's events and welcome them as an opportunity for training.

This is a quote from an article on cognitive psychology:

Research has shown that repeated action, learning, and memory can actually change the nervous system physically, altering both synaptic strength and connections. Such changes may be brought about by cultivated change in emotion and action; they will, in turn, change subsequent experience.³

In our KF meetings, we learn to do just that: we cultivate change in our emotions and actions, which in turn changes our subsequent experience.

Our prayer might go something like this:

*Jesus, Man of Sorrows, show me the power of Your resurrection in my suffering.*⁴ (Repeat)

Take a deep breath.

(If time permits, ask, "Does anyone have comments or questions about the Toolbox?")

0:30 SHARING

1:00 BIBLE TEACHING

Our healing begins with KF Confession number 7:

We commit now to live in reality, choosing to believe rather than judge.

Dig around in your toolbox and pull out your Bibles. This is your most powerful tool for life. If you have your Bible with you, turn to the third chapter of James.

James begins this chapter with a long discourse on how much trouble you can cause with your tongue. From our mouths pour sharp, pointed words that do harm and, also, healthy words that do good. It is an inescapable truth that your words reflect the real condition of your soul. Have you noticed what comes

out of your mouth when you are distressed, suffering, angry, or euphoric? By mindfully listening to yourself, you can learn about the actual level of your development.

I have paraphrased the text for this lesson using KF language and my own translation. The word *wisdom* can be a little confusing, so I have translated the Greek word for wisdom as *cleverness*. Cleverness in the context of this passage can be understood as the ability to be creative and skilled in practical matters—with a dash of real self-confidence. This kind of cleverness comes only through experience and training. Let's go ahead and read **James 3:13–18**.

¹³Which one of you has trained to be clever in practical matters and skills? Let that one bring their cleverness to light through excellent behavior and by using their tools gently, as if they were taming a wild animal and turning upside-down the direction of the animal's outcomes.

¹⁴If you have pointed or sharp rivalry within yourself—inner conflicts competing for your time, energy, and effort—and if in your heart you feel compelled by selfish ambition to satisfy the needs of your Idol, do not suppress your True Self or others with your egocentric self-promotion; in other words, do not cheat others with deceitful lies that oppose the reality of who you are and how the world really is. When you suppress reality, you take easy and habitual shortcuts—shortcuts that satisfy your compelling needs and relieve your basic anxiety—and you end up suppressing your True Self and the true potential of those around you. ¹⁵The cleverness of habitual shortcuts is not something that comes down from above; it comes from creeping along below on the earth having lost connection with heaven. Cleverness from below is egocentric like a wild animal—inviting, supporting, and motivated by demonic entities. ¹⁶You can look at it this way: wherever competing rivalry and selfish ambition exist, there is disorder, anarchy, and cheap, habitual, thoughtless behavior.

¹⁷But the cleverness from above is emphatically first of all holy, and it results in creating peace. It is fitting and appropriate, full of mercy and compassion, and it produces beneficial outcomes. This cleverness does not discriminate as to who benefits from its skills, and these skills are offered without pretense or acting out a role. ¹⁸How is all of this possible? It is possible through the harvest of orientation that has been reaped from seeds planted in peace by those who make peace.

Take a deep breath.

We learn in this passage that orientation is the fruit of the cleverness, or wisdom, from above. Wisdom is the ability to humbly apply knowledge in practical ways that benefit oneself and the community. James tells us that we can only apply this knowledge in our lives and produce oriented outcomes if we learn the practical skills of cultivating peace, first in our own souls and then in the community. We begin by resolving our own misoriented internal conflicts. Then, into that soil of inner calm, we can plant seeds of oriented choices and actions which produce the fruit of oriented outcomes—outcomes that promote harmonious and peaceful living and help restore the balance of the Creation. We know that this calmness in our soul is healthy for our physical, mental, and spiritual well-being. Our inner calm is also healthy for those around us, and it is certainly healthy for the purposes of God.

In our last lesson, we learned how Paul found this place of peace despite the discomfort of his imagined

limitations. God did not remove the limitations that Paul thought were hindering him; instead, God reminded Paul that it is through wrestling with these limitations and weaknesses that we develop strength and trust and grow our relationship with Him. Paul, therefore, willingly—and even eagerly—accepted the training of his weaknesses, confident in Christ’s ability to produce in him soul-strength through his struggle with those weaknesses. In the midst of various trials, he was willing to submit to the difficult process of becoming all that God created him to be. Paul’s karis gift to God was his laborious effort to develop and mature his strength—and that is a great gift, worthy of the karis invitation that God extended to him.

James warns us against falling back into old habits of the cleverness from below and encourages us to access the cleverness from above, which produces orientation and promotes peace. We can then use this cleverness to create peace within ourselves, and into that soil of peace we can plant the seeds of thought and action that will produce a harvest of oriented outcomes.

Our prayer might go something like this:

Prince of Peace, show me how to cultivate peace. (Repeat)

Take a deep breath.

(If time permits, ask, “Does anyone have comments or questions about the Bible teaching?”)

1:10 INTEGRATION

Sip some purified water, and you might prepare to take some notes. Assume a meditation posture, and breathe. *(Pause for 10 seconds)*

Here is our integration focus: *Consider an area of your life that needs training in practical skills. (Repeat) (Pause for 30 seconds)*

The FAITH Process

(Choose from each section a few sentences that are meaningful to you)

Feelings

As you *consider an area of your life that needs training in practical skills*, breathe and notice whatever you may be feeling. *(Pause)* Your feelings are important and deserve your attention and care. They are yours to teach you about yourself, to guide you, and to train you. They can often be uncomfortable. Recognize with compassion whatever you are experiencing, and breathe. *(Pause for 30 seconds)*

Awareness without judgment

Allow whatever you are experiencing to rest in your awareness as you *consider this area of your life that needs training*. Hold and observe your experience without judgment. *(Pause)* Feelings and passing thoughts are not right or wrong; they just are. You might simply observe and breathe with a long exhaling breath. *(Pause for 30 seconds)*

Inquiry: What is my body saying?

Bring your attention to your body and notice what it is doing when you *consider this area of your life that is unskilled and needs training*. *(Pause)* You might acknowledge right now what sensations are in your body. What might they be telling you? Observe those sensations, and breathe. *(Pause for 30 seconds)*

Talk to Jesus

You might imagine that you are leaning back in the safe and loving arms of Jesus as together you *consider this area of your life that is unskilled and needs training*. *(Pause)* Do you feel compelled to judge your lack of skill as good or evil? *(Pause)* What do you believe about yourself when you recognize that you need training? What story do you want to tell? *(Pause)* Are you telling the same story about other areas of your life? Is this story from your past? *(Pause)* Could you be feeling hurt pride because you need training? *(Pause)* Observe your experience as just information. You might process with a long exhaling breath or with the Dragon Breath.⁵ *(Pause for 30 seconds)*

Heal

As you breathe, repeat the word *Welcome*. *(Pause for 10 seconds)*

(Pause for 8 seconds or one long breath after each statement)

- Welcome this opportunity to train and grow.
- Welcome the Holy Spirit of truth, who wants to explore your real abilities.
- Welcome where you are today and the progress you have made.
- Welcome what you are learning about yourself. *(Pause for 10 seconds)*

Now, as you breathe, you might use the following statements as a confession to the Lord and turn away from the Idol Self. On the exhale, let go.⁶

(Pause for 5 seconds after each statement)

- While I recognize this opportunity to train, I let go of the craving to have my own way and impose my opinions.
- While I recognize this opportunity to train, I let go of the craving for respect and affection.
- While I recognize this opportunity to train, I let go of the craving for security and comfort.
- While I recognize this opportunity to train, I let go of the craving for perfection. *(Pause for 30 seconds)*

Take a deep breath.

(If time permits, ask, "Does anyone have comments or questions about the integration?")

1:28 ENDING PRAYER

Dear Father and Creator,

Thank You for this time to heal and train together. Hold us in the power of this new direction as You guide us to our real glory. Encourage us in our next training opportunity as we co-labor with You to reorient our lives for a more effective flow and to flourish in our connection with our True Self, with the Creation, and with You, for the glory and honor of our Lord Jesus. Amen.

Take a deep breath.

(If time permits, ask, "Does anyone have comments or questions about this meeting?")

1:29 ANNOUNCEMENTS

*This is the time in our KF training cycle to consider whether we, as KF members, want to offer the next NHG book study to our wider community. All current members are invited to participate in offering this

gift by signing up on the spreadsheet sent with the recent email from admin.

The Romans study begins in mid-October. If you are interested in participating, please register on the website.

*(*Except when preparing for the Jubilee year)*

¹ *It Is Well with My Soul* by Horatio Spafford (1828–1888); www.youtube.com/watch?v=6C0tiEVRlvs.

² en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Tapas_Acupressure_Technique.

³ Maggie Macnab, *Decoding Design: Understanding and Using Symbols in Visual Communication* (How Books, 2008), 174.

⁴ Phil. 3:10.

⁵ See KF12.

⁶ www.camillecaldwell.com/WelcomePrayer.html. Adapted for Karis Fellowships by Nancy Diven.